

 Demography

Child-headed households

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Definition

A child-only household is defined as a household in which all members are younger than 18 years. These households are also commonly referred to as “child-headed households”, although this definition differs from the technical definition contained in the Children’s Act.

The Children’s Act definition of a child-headed household includes households where there are adults who may be too sick or too old to head the household effectively and a child over 16 years bears this responsibility. It is not possible to count this type of child-headed household from the available survey data, as the designation "child-headed household" can only be conferred by the provincial Department of Social Development, To date, there are no administrative data available on the number of designated child-headed households.

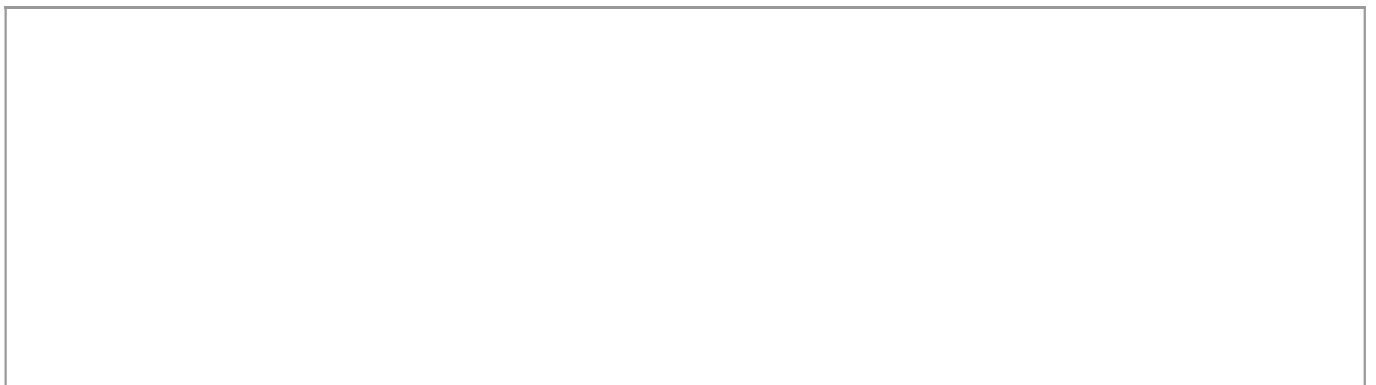
Data

Bar Trend Table

Province ▼

2002 ▼

2024 ▼





Source Statistics South Africa (2003 – 2025) General Household Survey 2002 – 2024. Pretoria, Cape Town: Statistics South Africa.
Analysis by Katharine Hall & Sumaiyah Hendricks, Children’s Institute, University of Cape Town.

- Notes**
- 1. Children are defined as persons aged 0 – 17 years.
 - 2. Population numbers have been rounded off to the nearest thousand.
 - 3. Sample surveys are always subject to error, and the proportions simply reflect the mid-point of a possible range. The confidence intervals (CIs) indicate the reliability of the estimate at the 95% level. This means that, if independent samples were repeatedly taken from the same population, we would expect the proportion to lie between upper and lower bounds of the CI 95% of the time. The wider the CI, the more uncertain the proportion. Where CIs overlap for different sub-populations or time periods we cannot be sure that there is a real difference in the proportion, even if the mid-point proportions differ. CIs are represented in the bar graphs by vertical lines at the top of each bar.

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